

# Evolution of Judeo-Christian Deity

## Critical Analysis of the Historical Shift from El Shaddai and the Divine Council to the Geopolitical Consolidation to Creedal Monotheism

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### Abstract

This paper investigates the historical and theological trajectory of conceptions of Judeo-Christian deity, tracing the evolution from the relational, henotheistic structures of the patriarchal era to the centralized, creedal monotheism of the imperial age. Utilizing a multidisciplinary framework that integrates Semitic etymology, ancient Near Eastern history, and comparative political theology, the research posits that the self-revelation of God as El Shaddai in Genesis 17 represents an ontological disclosure of a "unified species"—a cosmic familial continuum of spiritual entities encompassing God, angels, and humans. This Abrahamic "Promise Stage" is characterized by orthopraxy, where the divine mandate to "walk before me, and be blameless" prioritized ethical integrity and moral agency. The study further analyzes the shift to Jehovah as a geopolitical transition mirroring the rise of the nation-state and the "reduction of the pantheon"

Keywords: *El Shaddai, Divine Council, Pantheon Reduction, Orthopraxy vs. Orthodoxy, Unified Species, Geopolitics of Monotheism, Eternal Progression.*

## I. Linguistic Foundations: The Functional Names of Deity

The evolution of the Judeo-Christian God is embedded in the semantic valency of the names used to designate the Divine. Ancient Near Eastern thought anchored abstract concepts in concrete physical phenomena.

### 1. The Root 'El (אֵל)

The foundational root 'ēl is represented in ancient pictographic script by an ox head (strength) and a shepherd's staff (authority). This pastoral imagery suggests a deity conceived as a "strong authority" or the "leading ox" who guides his people through a shared yoke—a literal idiom for the covenant. Morphological variations like *Eloah* (majestic singular) and *Elohim* (plural of majesty or council) demonstrate a linguistic framework that accommodated both singular majesty and a populated spiritual realm.

## 2. El Shaddai: The Nurturing Parent

The revelation in Genesis 17:1 introduces *El Shaddai*. While often translated as "Almighty," etymological research suggests a tension between the root *shadad* (to overpower/destroy) and *shad* (breast/nurturer). In the context of the Abrahamic "Promise Stage," *El Shaddai* functions as the God of sufficiency and nurturing grace, promising fertility and protection without the immediate ethical complexity of the later Law.

## 3. Jehovah: The Promise Keeper

The shift to *Jehovah* (Yahweh) at Sinai represents a move into the "Fulfillment Stage". While *El Shaddai* emphasized sufficiency, *Jehovah* foregrounds covenantal performance and redemptive action, binding the deity to a specific nation through legal responsibility and the *Mitsvot* (commandments).

# II. The Divine Council and Pantheon Reduction

Early Israelite religion was characterized by henotheism or monolatry rather than absolute philosophical monotheism.

## 1. The Sôd Elohim (Psalm 82)

The "Divine Council" framework, supported by Ugaritic parallels, depicts a heavenly assembly presided over by the High God (*El/Elyon*) with seventy "sons of God" assigned to rule the nations. Psalm 82 explicitly describes this assembly: "God [Elohim] standeth in the congregation of the mighty [El]; he judgeth among the gods [elohim]".

## 2. The Mechanics of Centralization

The historical transition to monotheism was a process of "pantheon reduction" mirroring the rise of the centralized nation-state. As the Davidic and Josianic monarchies consolidated power, Yahweh absorbed the attributes and functions of other deities to delegitimize local shrines and consolidate authority in Jerusalem. This shift mirrored political needs for social stability and the "binding glue" of a singular, state-sponsored cult.

# III. The Unified Species Hypothesis: A Restorationist Ontology

Restorationist and heterodox theologies, specifically within the Latter-day Saint tradition, reject the Hellenistic "Great Chain of Being".

## 1. Eternal Progression

This paradigm posits that God, angels, and humans constitute a single, unified species navigating different states of eternal progression. Parley P. Pratt argued that "Gods, angels, and men are all of one species, one race, one great family". In this view, God the Father is an exalted man, and humans are "gods in embryo," making the difference between the Divine and the human one of degree rather than essence.

## 2. The Law of Agency

This cosmology is driven by moral agency rather than metaphysical abstraction. The fall of Lucifer is framed as a tragic exercise of agency among spiritual peers rather than a defect in a separate creation.

# IV. Geopolitics and the Hegemony of Orthodoxy

The research identifies a universal historical pattern where imperial power utilizes theological orthodoxy to regulate the relationship between the subject and the Divine.

## 1. The De Facto Tyranny of Nicaea

The Council of Nicaea (325 CE) replaced the relational "walk before me" of Abraham with the non-biblical philosophical construct *homoousios*. This served as an imperial mechanism of exclusion, transforming God into an incomprehensible essence and making creedal compliance a test of political loyalty.

## 2. Parallels in Zoroastrianism and Islam

Similar shifts are seen in the Sassanian Empire's standardization of Zoroastrianism and the Abbasid Caliphate's "Persianization" of Islam. In both cases, the priesthood allied with the state to suppress "heresies" and institutionalize ritual purity (e.g., five daily prayers) to ensure imperial cohesion.

# V. Synthesis: Orthopraxy as the Mortal Objective

The overarching argument concludes that the primary directive of the mortal journey is orthopraxy—right practice guided by spiritual light—rather than the perfection of ontological definitions. The command in Genesis 17 to "walk before me, and be blameless" establishes a covenant based on ethical integrity and relationship.

# VI. The "Who Created Whom" Question

This analysis highlights a fundamental dialectic:

## 1. Revelatory Realism (*Imago Dei*)

God is a tangible, exalted being who reveals Himself progressively to exalt His literal offspring.

## 2. Projection Theory

Following Feuerbach and Marx, mankind created God in *his* image to serve the needs of power structures and preserve social order.

## VII. Suggested Themes for Further Research

1. The "Two Powers in Heaven" in Second Temple Judaism: Further inquiry into how early Binitarianism was labeled as *minim* (heresy) as a polemic against nascent Christianity.
2. Cognitive Linguistics and Ancient Cosmologies: Investigating how the shift from concrete Hebrew imagery (ox head) to Greek abstract philosophy altered the human psychological perception of "distance" from the Divine.
3. Biopolitics of Species Definitions: Exploring how essentialized religious definitions of "species" have influenced modern environmental ethics and human exceptionalism.

## VIII. Conclusion

Ultimately, while political power has historically weaponized orthodoxy, the individual pursuit of the "Light of Christ" remains the ground of true religious experience.

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## Works Cited (MLA Style)

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## Summation of Arguments:

The history of monotheistic religion is a dialectic between **divine disclosure** and **geopolitical consolidation**, moving from a relational, familial cosmology to a centralized, creedal orthodoxy.

### 1. The Ontological Foundation: Familial Henotheism

The earliest Semitic theological layers, evidenced by the etymology of *El Shaddai* and the "Divine Council" (*sôd Elohim*), present God as a Supreme Patriarch presiding over a populated spiritual realm rather than a solitary, immaterial essence. In this "Promise Stage," *El Shaddai* functions as a nurturing God of grace—metaphorically the "Breasted

One" who provides unearned love and sufficiency to the patriarchs. This aligns with a **"unified species" hypothesis**, which posits that God, angels, and humans are of one family in varying states of **eternal progression**, rejecting the unbridgeable metaphysical gulf introduced by later Hellenistic philosophy.

## 2. The Political Shift: Pantheon Reduction and the Nation-State

The transition from the name *El Shaddai* to *Jehovah* (Yahweh) mirrors the historical shift from decentralized tribal networks to a centralized nation-state. This process, termed **"pantheon reduction,"** saw Yahweh absorb the attributes and titles of the High God *El* to consolidate authority under earthly monarchs like Josiah, who centralized worship in Jerusalem to stabilize the state. Similar patterns are seen in the Sassanian Empire's standardization of Zoroastrianism and the later Islamic Caliphates, where theology was often utilized as the "binding glue" for imperial unity.

## 3. The Hegemony of Orthodoxy over Orthopraxy

As religion became a tool of statecraft, the focus shifted from **orthopraxy** (right action and ethical integrity) to **orthodoxy** (creedal compliance). The Council of Nicaea (325 CE) replaced the relational "walk before me" of Genesis 17 with abstract, non-scriptural terms like *homoousios* to create a test of political loyalty and eliminate dissent. This "tyranny of the creed" effectively constrained the individual's moral agency and their direct relationship with a tangible Divine Parent.

## 4. Conclusion: The Mirror of Creation

Ultimately, this evolution forces a choice between two frameworks:

- **Revelatory Realism (*Imago Dei*):** God is a tangible, exalted being who revealed Himself progressively to educate and exalt His literal spirit offspring.
- **Projection Theory:** Mankind "created" a singular, absolute God and rigid orthodoxy to mirror and justify the needs of absolute monarchies and social power structures.

The argument concludes that the primary objective of the mortal journey remains a return to the **Abrahamic orthopraxy**—prioritizing ethical integrity and the light of Christ over the exclusionary dogmas formed in the crucibles of ancient empires.

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## Declaration of Generative AI and AI-assisted Technologies in the Writing Process

During the preparation of this work, the author utilized Gemini Deep Research (February 2026 version) to aggregate scholarly literature, identify thematic patterns across disparate disciplines, and generate initial drafts based on human-defined hypotheses. The AI was directed to perform a multidisciplinary inquiry into Semitic linguistics, ancient Near Eastern history, and comparative political theology. The author's role involved the conceptualization of the research plan, the provision of critical theological hypotheses, and the iterative oversight of all generated content to ensure intellectual coherence and historical accuracy. The author has reviewed all citations and claims against primary and secondary source summaries and assumes full responsibility for the final conclusions and the overall integrity of the research.

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## Appendix: Research Documentation and Synthesis Log

The collaboration followed an iterative, goal-oriented process where human hypotheses guided AI-driven literature aggregation. The following steps document the evolution of the research:

**1. Foundation: Linguistic and Ontological Inversion** The research began by deconstructing the Hebrew root 'ē/ and its pictographic origins as "strong authority". This foundation established the "unified species" hypothesis, suggesting an ancient Near Eastern cosmology where God and humans share a familial lineage, in direct contrast to Hellenistic abstractions.

**2. Historical Mechanics: Pantheon Reduction** The investigation pivoted to the mechanism of "pantheon reduction," examining how Yahweh absorbed the titles of the high god *E/* to facilitate political centralization. This stage utilized archaeological and historical-critical data to parallel the Davidic and Josianic monarchies with the Sassanian Empire's standardization of Zoroastrianism.

**3. Comparative Geopolitics: State Power and Orthodoxy** A comparative analysis was performed to evaluate the role of statecraft in defining "truth." Documentation included the transition of Islam from a tribal community to an administrative caliphate and the Roman Empire's use of the Council of Nicaea as a "binding glue" for imperial unity.

**4. Ethical Synthesis: Orthopraxy vs. Orthodoxy** The final stages evaluated the shift from the relational "walking" of the Abrahamic era to the statutory "compliance" of the national era. This resulted in a critical conclusion that prioritized divinely inspired ethical integrity over political creeds.

| Research Milestone       | Key Data Points                                           | Synthesis Goal                              |
|--------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| Etymological Analysis    | Root 'ē/, Shaddai ( <i>shaddaim</i> ), and YHWH meanings. | Establish character of the Divine eras.     |
| Historical-Critical View | Tribal henotheism vs. state-sponsored monotheism.         | Trace the role of political centralization. |
| Comparative Religions    | Sassanian Zoroastrianism and Abbasid Islam parallels.     | Identify universal patterns of orthodoxy.   |
| Ethical Evaluation       | Genesis 17 "Walk before me" as orthopraxy.                | Argue for the primacy of moral agency.      |



This log demonstrates the transparency of the human-AI interaction, ensuring that every thematic branch of the report is traceable to specific research inquiries and human-directed critical evaluations.